Integrating Narrative & Worldbuilding into Game Design

Due: March 11 by11:30 PM Brightspace Dropbox (Team-based submission)

Objective: Students will take their existing game idea, mechanics, and level design and enhance their worldbuilding by incorporating narrative elements, environmental storytelling, and systemic interactions within Unity. The goal is to make the world feel alive and meaningful through embedded storytelling and interaction mechanics.

Prerequisites:

- A basic Unity scene with a working level (can be blockout or prototype stage).
- Some existing player mechanics (e.g., movement, interaction).
- A general concept of the game's world, theme, and tone.

Learning Outcomes:

- Understand how environmental storytelling shapes player perception.
- Implement narrative triggers and interactive storytelling mechanics.
- Integrate diegetic world elements to reinforce immersion.

Step 1: Establish the Narrative Context

Each team writes a one-page narrative brief answering the following questions:

1. What happened in this world before the player arrived?
2. Who are the key figures or entities that shaped this world?
3. How does the environment reflect this history?
4. What interactive elements reinforce this story without using cutscenes?
5. Any of the questions we covered in class?

Example: If the game is set in a ruined city, instead of a text-based exposition, students should consider environmental clues (abandoned buildings, broken signs, NPC behaviors).

Step 2: Environmental Storytelling Implementation (45 mins)

Using Unity's Prefab System, Particle Effects, and Lighting, you will implement three environmental storytelling elements in their level.

1. Prop-based storytelling: Place objects in meaningful arrangements (e.g., tipped-over furniture suggests struggle, vines over structures suggest long abandonment).

2. Light & Atmosphere: Modify Unity's lighting to reinforce tone (e.g., flickering lights in horror, warm glow in peaceful areas).

3. Decals & Details: Use terrain tools, decals (footprints, bloodstains, graffiti) to hint at past events.

Example: If an ancient war destroyed the city, they might add crater impacts, skeletal remains, or ruined banners instead of just empty streets.

Step 3: Interactive Narrative Triggers (45 mins)

You will create at least one interactive narrative trigger using Unity's Trigger Colliders and Dialogue Systems.

1. Create a Unity Trigger Collider on a specific location (doorway, artifact, abandoned house).

2. Attach a Narrative Event:

    - Use Text Mesh Pro to display short text pop-ups.

    - Use Unity's Audio Source to play a recorded message or an ambient sound that suggests history (e.g., ghostly whispers, distant battles).

    - Use NPC behaviors (via NavMesh) to show characters reacting to the player's presence.

Example: In a sci-fi game, stepping near a destroyed AI facility could trigger a broken transmission log with distorted audio instead of a cutscene.

Step 4: Dynamic Worldbuilding with Simple Systems (30 mins)

You will add one dynamic worldbuilding system to enhance immersion. Choose one:

1. Time-based world change – Use Unity's Animator & Timeline to shift environments (e.g., a ruined house that gradually reconstructs via animation when a puzzle is solved).

2. Player Impact on the World – Create a simple interaction where objects change state (e.g., lighting a torch, unlocking an ancient mechanism, triggering an NPC reaction).

3. Procedural Worldbuilding – Randomized events (e.g., weather changes, random NPC dialogues, destructible objects that change the game space).

Example: In a mystery game, collecting certain objects might make new environmental clues appear dynamically, reinforcing non-linear storytelling.

Step 5: Playtest & Storytelling Walkthrough (30 mins)

Each team walks another team/friends/peers through their world, explaining how environmental elements, interactive triggers, and systems contribute to worldbuilding.

- Peers explore without prior knowledge and guess the backstory based on the world alone.
- The designing team can then clarify their intended vs. actual player perception.

Reflection: What elements effectively conveyed the world's story? What was ambiguous or underdeveloped? What will be the future steps?

Submission Instructions

Please prepare a **zipped file** for Brightspace containing your **one-page narrative brief** (covering world backstory, key figures, and environmental storytelling approach) and **Unity build** or **Unity project folder** that demonstrates the required worldbuilding elements (three environmental storytelling props/arrangements, one interactive trigger with narrative content, and one dynamic worldbuilding system). Within the same ZIP, include a short **reflection document** detailing your playtest results—what players inferred from the environment, how that compared to your intended story, and potential improvements—ensuring everything is clearly labeled and ready for submission by the due date.